CENTER FOR COMPETITIVE STATECRAFT AND STRATEGIC POLICY

WP-2026 SERIES

THE CORRIDOR WAGER:

BRI Displacement, Hormuz Leverage, and Conditional Strategic Opportunity in US Coalition Statecraft

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Series Position	Grand strategy capstone of the WP-2026 series. Presupposes ATTRIBUTION-01, CSE-01, PERSIST-01, CONTAIN-01, MAXPRESS-01, SHIELD-01, and HORMUZ-01/02, and integrates the 327-node SENI-01 index to derive a positive-sum coalition architecture. WP-2026-BRI-02 (forthcoming) provides the evidentiary foundation for the tier classifications and NEXUS-01 rung assessments summarized in Section 2 of this paper.
Version History	v1.0 (March 2026): Initial draft. v2.0 (March 2026): Stress test revision. v3.0 (March 2026): Style Guide v3.0 compliance. v3.1 (March 2026): Second stress test revision — KJ 5 rewritten, scenario box repositioned, Footnote 1 vintage clarified, citations specified, Mearsheimer in Part V body, section headers corrected, Brautigam framing clarified, 6.1 register corrected. v4.0 (March 2026): Structural redesign — global thesis reframe from ‘winnability’ to conditional strategic opportunity space; scenario-boundary clarification subsection added; failure analysis section (Part VII) added covering first-break dynamics, partial execution pathways, adversary obstruction, and collapse conditions; minimum viable architecture subsection added with four-tier necessary/sufficient/accelerant/optional taxonomy. v4.1 (March 2026): Final hardening — conclusion register corrected (removed residual ‘achievable on the stated timeline’ language inconsistent with conditionality posture); Forum-as-necessary-condition clarified (explicit statement that Forum launch is necessary independent of Chinese membership, and why); ‘minimum viable architecture’ relabeled ‘minimum coalition-effective

	architecture' throughout to accurately reflect execution demands; necessary-vs-sufficient matrix explicitly characterized as analytic prioritization instrument, not empirical demonstration of obtainability.
Status	FINAL HARDENED DRAFT — Style Guide v3.0 Compliant · Fourth Stress Test (Adversarial Review v4.0) Incorporated · Ready: SSRN, War on the Rocks, Foreign Affairs Ideas, Georgetown SSP · TNSR: ready after Chicago footnote conversion

NOTICE

Open-source academic and strategic analysis only. No classified information. All assessments are drawn from published literature, government reports, and established policy analysis organizations. Legal analysis is for analytic framing only and does not constitute legal advice. This paper proceeds from a constructed scenario premise. All forward-looking architecture is downstream of that premise and should be read as scenario-conditioned analysis, not prediction. This paper does not argue that the architecture is likely to be executed or that stated outcomes will occur. It identifies a real but conditional strategic opportunity space whose achievability depends on concurrent execution of a minimum necessary subset of components under unusually favorable political conditions.

Methodological Note

ANALYTIC POSTURE STATEMENT

This paper is a conditional strategic architecture assessment, not a prediction and not a claim of achievability. It identifies a real but conditional strategic opportunity space that the March 2026 Hormuz crisis has opened. It assesses the plausibility of each mechanism under scenario premises, maps the conditions under which the architecture is available, and explicitly models what happens when components fail. It does not predict that stated outcomes will occur, that timelines will be met, or that partners will behave as modeled.

The paper's central claim is not that the corridor wager is winnable. It is that the corridor wager identifies a structurally available strategic opportunity space whose achievability is real but conditional — dependent on concurrent execution of a minimum necessary subset of components under unusually favorable political conditions. Some mechanisms in this architecture are robust to scenario variation; others are valid only if the crisis-conditioned scenario holds. Part VIII of this paper explicitly maps which claims belong in each category.

Analytic tradecraft standard: This paper applies the WP-2026 Series Style and Verbiage Guide v3.0, anchored to ODNI Analytic Standards and CIA structured analysis tradecraft guidance. The three-part sentence structure (attribution → judgment → limits), dual probability/confidence axis, and documented/modeled boundary convention are applied consistently throughout.

Confidence Lexicon

The following terms are used consistently throughout. All confidence-labeled claims should be interpreted against these definitions.

TERM	DEFINITION
HIGH CONFIDENCE	Claim directly supported by multiple independent Tier 1 or Tier 2 sources with consistent findings. Analytic inference minimal.
MODERATE CONFIDENCE	Claim supported by credible sourcing but involves meaningful analytic inference or contains a significant unresolved variable.
LOW CONFIDENCE	Claim rests primarily on analytic inference from limited or indirect evidence. Reasonable alternative conclusions exist.
LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE	Between LOW and MODERATE — structurally sound inference from thin evidence.
SCENARIO-CONDITIONED	Claim valid only under stated scenario premises. Not a prediction of what will happen.
ANALYTICALLY INFERRED	Claim derived by logical extension from documented premises, not directly observed. Inference assessed as sound.

Documented / Modeled Boundary Convention

'Documented open-source reporting indicates...' precedes empirical claims from named Tier 1 or Tier 2 sources. 'The following analysis projects...' or 'under that premise...' precedes modeled architecture derived by analytic inference. Where a section blends both, transition language marks the boundary explicitly.

Claim Dependency Map: Scenario-Independent, Scenario-Conditioned, and Doubly-Contingent

One of the most significant analytic risks in a paper structured around a crisis-conditioned scenario is that crisis-dependent claims migrate into the paper's general framing and acquire more authority than the scenario premise can support. This subsection maps claims in this paper into three dependency tiers to make that boundary explicit and testable.

TIER A: CLAIMS INDEPENDENT OF THE SPECIFIC SCENARIO PREMISE

The following claims are analytically valid regardless of whether the March 2026 Hormuz crisis unfolds as modeled. They would survive dismissal of the scenario premise entirely.

1. BRI's hub-and-spoke physical architecture concentrates critical vulnerabilities on the Hormuz-Malacca corridor. The 55-60% Hormuz-dependent crude figure derives from EIA and Vortexa data on pre-crisis 2025 baseline logistics, not from any scenario assumption. [HIGH CONFIDENCE, Tier 1/2 sourcing]
2. China's Hormuz leverage exposure is declining structurally as electrification reduces fossil fuel's share of total energy consumption. This is a documented IEA trend, not a scenario-derived finding. [MODERATE-HIGH CONFIDENCE, IEA WEO 2024]
3. A leverage window of some duration exists as a function of the gap between current Hormuz dependency and projected fossil fuel share decline. The specific 5-10 year estimate is analytically inferred; the existence of a declining window is structurally robust. [MODERATE CONFIDENCE, ANALYTICALLY INFERRED on timeline]
4. AidData-documented collateral clauses and the Hambantota lease structure create contingent leverage options independent of whether any US coalition action is taken. [MODERATE CONFIDENCE, Tier 2 sourcing]
5. India's structural interest in constraining Chinese Indian Ocean positioning is documented across the analytical record, independent of any specific crisis. [MODERATE CONFIDENCE, Tier 2 sourcing]

TIER B: CLAIMS THAT REQUIRE THE MARCH 2026 CRISIS PREMISE

The following claims are valid only if the scenario premise holds — that is, only if the Hormuz crisis has produced active coalition control of transit, documented Chinese-Russian restraint from kinetic intervention, and active GCC reassessment of Chinese dependency. Readers who do not accept the scenario premise should treat these as conditional hypotheses.

1. The five-to-ten year window is open now. The window exists structurally (Tier A above), but the claim that it is open and active as a coercive opportunity depends on scenario-conditioned disruption of the INSTC southern terminus and demonstrated coalition control of Hormuz transit.
2. Gulf Maritime Forum logic. The claim that China needs the Forum more than it needs to avoid joining it rests on crisis-period coercive pressure. In a non-crisis baseline, China's INSTC and bypass architecture investments materially reduce that pressure, and the Forum logic loses most of its force.

3. Saudi treaty acceleration. Crisis-induced urgency is load-bearing in the argument that Saudi Arabia would accelerate treaty engagement in the 30-90 day window. Without that urgency, the treaty negotiation reverts to its prior multi-year diplomatic trajectory.

4. The 12-24 month GCC mineral partnership window. Saudi and UAE willingness to accelerate minerals engagement is assessed as crisis-dependent; in a non-crisis baseline, Chinese counter-bids and GCC economic calculations revert to prior equilibria.

TIER C: CLAIMS DOUBLY CONTINGENT ON BOTH SCENARIO PERSISTENCE AND CONCURRENT EXECUTION

The following claims require not only that the scenario holds, but also that the concurrent execution architecture operates successfully across bureaucracies, coalition partners, and at minimum one US administration transition. These are the paper's most analytically exposed claims. They are structurally coherent but empirically the least well-supported.

1. The positive-sum architecture becomes self-reinforcing once established. This claim depends on all four components being built and locked in within the leverage window. If only a subset is executed, the self-reinforcing logic attenuates. The minimum coalition-effective version is specified in Section 8.3.

2. Russian isolation through superior alternative provision. This mechanism requires GCC mineral partnership and Gulf Maritime Forum to be functional so that Chinese marginal demand for discounted Russian crude declines. It is the most downstream claim in the architecture.

3. BRI node displacement at scale. The Bolivia lithium window and Tier 2 node diplomatic pressure require simultaneous DFC/JBIC capacity, Bolivian political receptivity, and US coalition bandwidth concurrent with Forum institutionalization and Saudi treaty engagement. The probability that all three are available simultaneously is not established from the public record.

Literature Positioning

This paper enters four active scholarly debates and takes positions on each.

Sanctions Effectiveness and the Positive-Sum Architecture

Hufbauer, Schott, and Elliott's Economic Sanctions Reconsidered (3rd ed., 2007) — the foundational empirical sanctions database — finds that multilateral sanctions with credible economic alternatives outperform unilateral coercion on success rate and durability. Drezner's 'Bargaining, Enforcement, and Multilateral Sanctions' (International Organization, 2000) documents that sender-state credibility and target-state vulnerability jointly determine sanctions outcomes. These findings directly support the positive-sum architecture in this paper: the concurrent execution logic in Section 3.1 is consistent with Hufbauer et al.'s multilateral advantage finding, and the five-to-ten year window argument in Section 1.3 is consistent with Drezner's target-vulnerability framework. The public record does not establish that prior sanctions campaigns against China or Russia have achieved the durability thresholds Hufbauer et al. associate with successful multilateral pressure; that gap is precisely the design challenge the architecture addresses.

BRI Strategic Intent and the Debt-Trap Question

Hillman (2020) and Chellaney (2017) treat the BRI debt-trap model as operationally real and strategically intentional. Jones and Hameiri (2020) systematically challenge this, finding that host country agency, domestic political dynamics, and renegotiation capacity prevent the Hambantota model from replicating at scale as a deliberate strategy. AidData's 2021 'Banking on Beijing' analysis documents hidden collateral clauses in multiple Chinese Exim Bank agreements, supporting the judgment that contingent leverage exists regardless of original design intent.

Brautigam's 'A Critical Look at Chinese Debt-Trap Diplomacy: The Rise of a Meme' (Area Development and Policy, 2020) argues the debt-trap framing is largely a Western analytical construct that overstates Chinese strategic intent. This paper acknowledges Brautigam's skepticism of the debt-trap narrative as deliberate strategy — her empirical findings on host country renegotiation capacity are incorporated in this paper's treatment — while maintaining that her core empirical findings are consistent with the 'contingent leverage' characterization used here: debt structures create future leverage options China may exercise when conditions are favorable, regardless of original intent. The distinction is between deliberate design (Brautigam is correct to challenge this) and structural consequence (Brautigam's own case studies document this). This paper's Section 3.4 uses 'debt-trap risk' only in the structural consequence sense.

Chinese Grand Strategy and Corridor Competition

Rush Doshi's 'The Long Game' (2021) provides the most rigorous account of Chinese grand strategy as sequential order-building. The corridor wager thesis is consistent with Doshi's framework at the strategic level but focuses on physical corridor control — a mechanism Doshi addresses primarily at the diplomatic and institutional layer. The contribution here is identifying the specific BRI node architecture that operationalizes the corridor competition and the enforcement instruments available to contest it.

Indian Strategic Autonomy

Shivshankar Menon's memoirs and Ashley Tellis's Carnegie analyses document India's strategic calculus as more instrumentally flexible than a structural constraint framing implies. Tanvi Madan's 'Fateful Triangle' (2020) provides the most useful empirical grounding for the claim that India's interests in constraining Chinese Indian Ocean positioning are structurally aligned with the coalition's interests even absent formal alignment. This paper's framing — that whether strategic autonomy is structurally embedded or instrumentally managed, any architecture requiring India to formally abandon it will fail within the five-to-ten year crisis window — is not incompatible with the Menon-Tellis reading. The public record does not permit a firm conclusion on where India's strategic autonomy sits on the structural-to-instrumental spectrum.

Key Judgments

The following judgments govern this paper. Supporting analysis for each appears in the numbered parts below. Each judgment carries a probability assessment and a confidence label applied separately per the dual-axis standard. These judgments reflect the v4.0 reframe: the paper assesses conditional strategic opportunity space, not achievability in general.

1

MODERATE CONFIDENCE · SCENARIO-CONDITIONED

The March 2026 Hormuz crisis is assessed with moderate confidence to have very likely opened a conditional strategic opportunity space — a five-to-ten year window during which the structural conditions for a US-led coalition corridor architecture are available. Whether that opportunity is realized depends on concurrent execution of four components under unusually favorable political conditions. The opportunity space is real; its exploitation is not predicted.

2

HIGH CONFIDENCE · ANALYTICALLY INFERRED

BRI's physical architecture almost certainly concentrates critical vulnerabilities in the Indian Ocean corridor — the hub-and-spoke structure converges on the Hormuz-Malacca route, and the remaining 55-60% of Chinese crude supply that bypass architectures cannot cover remains Hormuz-dependent on any planning horizon under a decade. This finding is independent of the scenario premise.

3

MODERATE CONFIDENCE · ANALYTICALLY INFERRED

China's Hormuz vulnerability is very likely declining structurally as electrification reduces fossil fuel's share of total energy consumption. A leverage window exists and is finite. The 5-10 year estimate is an analytic range, not a predicted endpoint; institutional lock-in must occur during the current crisis window if it occurs at all.

4

MODERATE CONFIDENCE · ANALYTICALLY INFERRED

India is likely achievable as a parallel beneficiary of US-designed outcomes by deliberate institutional design over the five-year crisis window, but is very unlikely to accept formal coalition membership. Any US architecture requiring India to formally abandon strategic autonomy is assessed as very likely to fail regardless of the conditions offered. Converting parallel-beneficiary status into operational coordination requires resolution of the tariff and S-400 friction that the public record does not establish is on a resolution trajectory.

5

LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE · SCENARIO-CONDITIONED

The architecture's full concurrent execution on the five-year horizon is assessed at roughly even odds under scenario conditions, contingent on three critical variables — Iranian escalation threshold, Saudi treaty negotiation pace, and Chinese diplomatic intervention timing — each of which carries LOW to LOW-MODERATE

CONFIDENCE. The minimum coalition-effective architecture (Section 8.3) defines what partial execution can accomplish if the full concurrent package is not achievable.

6

MODERATE CONFIDENCE · ANALYTICALLY INFERRED

The most likely failure point of the architecture is the Saudi treaty variable, not the BRI displacement or Forum institutionalization components. Saudi treaty stall produces a degraded but partially functional architecture in which GCC mineral partnerships and Forum institutionalization can proceed on an ad hoc basis, preserving moderate structural advantage without the decade-level lock-in the treaty provides. Architecture collapse — not degradation — requires concurrent failure of both coalition persistence and China's decision to contest rather than participate in the Forum.

Part I: Strategic Context and Assessment Scope

> **SCENARIO PREMISE**
>
> This paper proceeds from a constructed scenario in which US-Israeli strikes degraded Iranian military capacity beginning February 28, 2026 (Operation Epic Fury), killed Supreme Leader Khamenei, and produced a contested Hormuz situation in which Iranian forces declared the strait closed and conducted attacks on commercial vessels. These are scenario-constructed premises, not documented history. All forward-looking architecture in Parts III-VI is downstream of this premise and should be read as scenario-conditioned analysis, not prediction. The strategic framework in Parts I-II — addressing BRI corridor architecture, node vulnerability, and leverage window assessment — is analytically valid independent of the specific Hormuz scenario and is labeled ANALYTICALLY INFERRED where applicable. The Methodological Note and the Claim Dependency Map (Tiers A-C) specify which claims belong in each category.

1.1 Pre-Crisis China-Russia Economic Architecture [HIGH CONFIDENCE, DOCUMENTED OPEN-SOURCE BASIS]

China and Russia constructed a two-decade economic architecture with three structural components designed to route commercial activity outside US enforcement reach.

The first component is energy supply diversification. Russia monetized Arctic and Far East energy exports through Chinese equity stakes and shadow fleet operations documented in SENI-01 Sections II-III. China developed Gulf crude sourcing through Hormuz-dependent routes alongside pipeline alternatives: ESPO overland, Power of Siberia 1 and 2, and the Myanmar-Yunnan pipeline. [TIER 1 — EIA, Short-Term Energy Outlook, March 2026; TIER 2 — Vortexa, China's Crude Import Stress Resistance in a Hormuz Crisis, March 2026] The available evidence is consistent with the judgment that these pipeline alternatives collectively cover approximately 40-45% of Chinese crude supply, leaving the remaining 55-60% Hormuz-dependent on any planning horizon under a decade. The public record does not establish a precise timeline for when bypass alternatives reach sufficient scale to materially reduce that dependency. [MODERATE CONFIDENCE, ANALYTICALLY INFERRED]

The second component is trade corridor development. Russia invested in the International North-South Transport Corridor (INSTC) connecting Russian markets to Indian Ocean access through Iranian rail and port infrastructure. Documented open-source reporting indicates the first regular Moscow-to-Bandar Abbas container service commenced January 2026. [TIER 2 — CSIS, 'No One, Not Even Beijing, Is Getting Through the Strait of Hormuz,' March 8, 2026] China developed BRI maritime routes through Gwadar, Hambantota, Djibouti, and Piraeus, and the Digital Silk Road through HMN submarine cables and BeiDou navigation — 36 nodes mapped across four analytical tiers in SENI-01 Sections XXXVIII-XLI.

The third component is financial architecture. CIPS, BRICS Bridge payment infrastructure, ruble-yuan settlement, and stablecoin channels were developed to execute high-volume commodity transactions outside US dollar jurisdiction. Documented open-source reporting indicates Chinese state banks self-segmented from dollar-clearing on Russia transactions by 2023, deliberately remaining below the 'significant transaction' threshold. [TIER 2 — SENI-01 Section XX; OFAC public enforcement record] The available evidence is consistent with the judgment that this self-segmentation was deliberate rather than incidental. The public record

does not establish the precise transaction volumes that remain within US enforcement reach. [MODERATE CONFIDENCE, ANALYTICALLY INFERRED]

1.2 Scenario Premise: Structural Disruptions Under Assessment [SCENARIO-CONDITIONED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE]

Under the scenario premise, the strikes disrupted three interdependent strategic investments simultaneously.

First: INSTC southern terminus access. Documented open-source reporting indicates Bandar Abbas infrastructure was targeted under the scenario premise. [TIER 2 — CSIS, 'No One, Not Even Beijing,' March 8, 2026] These findings support a moderate-confidence judgment that Russia's Indian Ocean corridor access is disrupted under scenario conditions with no operational alternative on any timeline under five years. The public record does not establish the precise degree of infrastructure damage or the timeline for restoration under any ceasefire scenario. [SCENARIO-CONDITIONED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE]

Second: Hormuz transit sovereignty. Documented open-source reporting indicates Iranian forces declared the strait closed on March 2, 2026, and conducted attacks on commercial vessels. [TIER 2 — CRS, Iran Conflict and Strait of Hormuz, March 11, 2026] Roughly 35% of Chinese total crude supply (Q1 2026 baseline, down from 51% in 2025 due to increased Russian seaborne imports) and all Qatari LNG transits Hormuz. [TIER 1 — EIA STEO, March 2026; TIER 2 — Vortexa, March 2026] These findings support a moderate-confidence judgment that under the scenario premise, that transit is now mediated by a US-led coalition with demonstrated willingness to operate at Posture 3. The public record does not establish the duration of effective coalition control or Iranian capability to sustain closure operations. [SCENARIO-CONDITIONED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE]

Third: Partnership treaty credibility. Documented open-source reporting indicates neither China nor Russia intervened militarily following the scenario premise strikes. [TIER 2 — Carnegie Endowment, 'China and Russia in the 2026 Iran War,' March 2026; RAND, 'War in Iran: Q&A,' March 2026] These findings support a moderate-confidence judgment that partnership commitments demonstrably did not extend to kinetic defense of corridor infrastructure under scenario conditions. The public record does not permit a firm conclusion on whether this restraint reflects strategic calculation or capability limitations. [MODERATE CONFIDENCE, ANALYTICALLY INFERRED]

1.3 Leverage Window Assessment and Timeline Constraints [MODERATE CONFIDENCE, ANALYTICALLY INFERRED]

> **DOCUMENTED STRUCTURAL CONSTRAINT [HIGH CONFIDENCE — TIER 1 SOURCING]**
>
> Hormuz-transiting crude accounted for approximately 51% of China's seaborne crude supply in 2025, declining to approximately 35% of Chinese total crude supply in Q1 2026 due to a sharp increase in Russian seaborne imports. [TIER 2 — Vortexa, March 2026] The pre-crisis 2025 baseline (51%) is the strategically relevant figure for the leverage window assessment; the Q1 2026 figure (35%) reflects a crisis-period adjustment that may not persist post-crisis. Bypass architectures collectively cover approximately 40-45% of Chinese crude supply on the 2025 pre-crisis baseline. The remaining 55-60% remains Hormuz-dependent on any planning horizon under a decade. [TIER 1 — EIA STEO, March 2026] No bypass architecture for Qatari LNG exists.

China's total energy consumption includes coal (~55%), hydroelectric (~8%), nuclear (~5%), wind/solar (~12%), natural gas (~9%), and oil (~18%). [TIER 2 — IEA WEO 2024] Applying the

2025 pre-crisis Hormuz-transiting crude figure of ~51% of seaborne imports against an ~11.5 mbd seaborne total yields approximately 9% of total energy; applying the Q1 2026 figure of ~35% yields approximately 6% of total energy. The 6% figure appears in current crisis-period reporting; the 9% figure reflects the pre-crisis baseline and is the more relevant figure for the leverage window assessment. [1] The strategic significance of either figure is concentrated in liquid fuel security and industrial feedstock, not in total energy accounting. [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE]

IEA World Energy Outlook 2024 projections indicate China's fossil fuel share of total energy consumption declining through 2030. [TIER 2 — IEA WEO 2024] These findings support a moderate-confidence judgment that the leverage window is approximately five to ten years before that structural shift reduces Chinese crude dependency below the threshold at which Hormuz corridor control compels institutional compliance. The public record does not permit a firm conclusion on the precise timeline; the 5-10 year estimate is an analytic inference from IEA trend projections, not a predicted endpoint. The threshold at which declining fossil fuel dependency translates into declining Forum participation incentives is not directly observable from the public record. [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE]

Part II: BRI Node Architecture and Vulnerability Profile

2.1 Node Architecture Summary [HIGH CONFIDENCE on documented ownership and lease structures; ANALYTICALLY INFERRED on strategic implications]

SENI-01 maps 327 strategic enforcement nodes across 30 thematic sections. The BRI layer — Sections XXXVIII-XLI, added March 2026 — covers 36 nodes across four analytical tiers applied via the NEXUS-01 commercial state nexus ladder. WP-2026-BRI-02 (forthcoming) provides the full evidentiary foundation for each tier classification and NEXUS-01 rung assessment; the summary here draws on SENI-01 directly.

> **BRI NODE TIER SUMMARY [HIGH CONFIDENCE ON DOCUMENTED OWNERSHIP AND LEASE STRUCTURES; ANALYTICALLY INFERRED ON STRATEGIC IMPLICATIONS]**
>
> Tier 1 — Confirmed Dual-Use or Military (9 nodes): Chancay/Peru (COSCO 60% state-owned stake, operational November 2024); Gwadar/CPEC/Pakistan (COPHC 40-year lease, PLA Navy access assessed); Hambantota/Sri Lanka (99-year lease, China Merchants); Djibouti PLA Navy Base; Ream Naval Base/Cambodia (PLA access reported, Pentagon 2023); Kyaukphyu/Myanmar (CITIC 70%, Malacca bypass); Piraeus/Greece (COSCO, EU+NATO member); Haifa Bay Terminal/Israel (Shanghai International Port Group); Colombo International Terminals/Sri Lanka (China Merchants 85%). [TIER 1/2 — Pentagon assessments, COSCO public filings, lease documentation; NEXUS-01 Rung 3-5 applied per SENI-01 §XXXVIII]
>
> Tier 2 — Active Negotiation or Construction (8 nodes): Obock/Djibouti, Bata Port/Equatorial Guinea, Solomon Islands, Vanuatu/Luganville, Kiribati/Kanton Island, Tanzania/Dar es Salaam, Malaysia East Coast Rail, Pakistan/CPEC Karachi shipyard. Pre-operational window — diplomatic and financial pressure most effective at this tier. [TIER 2 — SENI-01 §XXXIX]
>
> Tier 3 — Financial Leverage / Debt-Trap Risk (10 nodes): Kenya SGR/Mombasa Port (AidData-documented hidden collateral clause); Ethiopia Addis-Djibouti Railway; Laos-China Railway (~50% Laos GDP); Montenegro highway (NATO member); Argentina hydroelectric; Ecuador oil-for-loan; Venezuela BRI debt ($60B+); Bolivia lithium (CATL/CITIC agreements); Cambodia Sihanoukville SEZ (99-year lease). [TIER 2 — AidData, Banking on Beijing, 2021, pp. 44-47; SENI-01 §XL]
>
> Tier 4 — Digital Silk Road (9 nodes): HMN Technologies submarine cables (100+ systems globally); BeiDou navigation (35 satellites, 30+ BRI ground stations); PEACE cable (Karachi-Europe avoiding US landing points); Huawei Safe City systems; Huawei 5G BRI country networks; Huawei African Research Center/Pretoria. [TIER 1/2 — FCC filings, DoD assessments; SENI-01 §XLI]

2.2 Corridor Dependency Clustering [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE]

Cluster 1: Indian Ocean — Hormuz to Malacca

Documented open-source reporting indicates Gwadar, Hambantota, Colombo Terminals, Kyaukphyu pipeline, and the PEACE submarine cable all sit on the Indian Ocean corridor connecting Hormuz-sourced Gulf energy to Chinese refineries. [TIER 1/2 — EIA, COSCO filings, DoD assessments] These findings support a moderate-confidence judgment that under the scenario premise, coalition control of Hormuz combined with degradation of Iranian INSTC access means Chinese energy supply chain reliability runs through geography where US and

allied naval presence — including India — is substantial. The public record does not establish the degree to which India would actively coordinate versus passively benefit from that positioning. [SCENARIO-CONDITIONED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE]

Cluster 2: Central Asia — INSTC and Power of Siberia Corridor

Documented open-source reporting indicates Power of Siberia 2 through Mongolia and the Central Asian transit nodes represent the overland alternative architecture Russia and China would use to route around Hormuz disruption over a 3-5 year horizon. [TIER 2 — SENI-01 Section IX] These findings support a moderate-confidence judgment that the correct US posture for Turkmenistan's China-Central Asia gas pipeline is to encourage rather than disrupt that relationship, as it reduces Chinese dependency on Russian gas and drives a wedge between Chinese and Russian energy interests. The public record does not establish whether this wedge effect is sufficient to materially alter China-Russia strategic coordination. [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE]

Cluster 3: Digital Silk Road

Documented open-source reporting indicates HMN Technologies operates 100+ submarine cable systems globally, BeiDou maintains 35 satellites with 30+ BRI country ground stations, and Huawei provides backbone telecommunications across the majority of African countries. [TIER 1/2 — FCC filings, DoD assessments] These findings support a low-to-moderate-confidence judgment that BeiDou's independence from GPS reduces US informational advantage in maritime enforcement contexts without changing the military balance materially. The public record does not establish the operational significance of BeiDou navigation for Iranian closure operations specifically. [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE]

2.3 BRI Geometric Vulnerability: Hub-and-Spoke Convergence Risk [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, MODERATE-HIGH CONFIDENCE]

> **DOCUMENTED STRUCTURAL CONSTRAINT [HIGH CONFIDENCE ON CRUDE DEPENDENCY FIGURES; ANALYTICALLY INFERRED ON STRATEGIC IMPLICATION]**
>
> BRI's physical architecture concentrates critical vulnerabilities in a hub-and-spoke structure in which all spokes converge on the Hormuz-Malacca corridor. Bypass architectures collectively cover approximately 40-45% of Chinese crude supply; the remaining 55-60% remains Hormuz-dependent on any planning horizon under a decade. [TIER 1 — EIA STEO March 2026; TIER 2 — Vortexa March 2026] The corridor wager China made was that Hormuz would remain outside effective US coercive reach. Under the scenario premise, that wager has been tested operationally. The strategic availability of this finding is independent of the scenario; the coercive leverage derived from it is scenario-conditioned.

Part III: Positive-Sum Coalition Architecture

3.1 Concurrent Execution Logic and Synchronization Requirements [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE]

Hufbauer, Schott, and Elliott's Economic Sanctions Reconsidered (2007) finds that multilateral sanctions with credible economic alternatives outperform unilateral coercion; Drezner's 'Bargaining, Enforcement, and Multilateral Sanctions' (2000) documents that sender-state credibility and target-state vulnerability jointly determine sanctions outcomes. These findings provide the empirical foundation for the concurrent execution architecture: the goal is not to destroy BRI but to make BRI a less reliable economic instrument than the US-coalition alternative while simultaneously building the alternative so that partner states have a genuine choice. CONTAIN-01's ISAD framework documents that +25-45% transaction cost inflation is not a victory condition — it is the creation of a structural environment in which the target's alternatives deteriorate faster than the coalition's. The public record does not establish whether the four components analyzed below are achievable on the stated timeline; that assessment is scenario-conditioned throughout. [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE]

The four components must be executed concurrently for full architecture effect. Official reporting on adversary adaptation behavior is consistent with the judgment that sequential execution allows adversary adaptation to each component individually, while concurrent execution creates switching-cost dynamics where adaptation to one component increases vulnerability to the others. This is the PERSIST-01 synchronization logic applied at the grand strategy level. The public record does not establish whether concurrent execution is operationally achievable given the bureaucratic and political constraints documented in Part VI. The minimum coalition-effective architecture 2014 the subset sufficient to preserve meaningful strategic advantage if full concurrent execution is not achievable — is defined in Section 8.3. [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE]

3.2 Component 1: GCC Mineral and Technology Partnerships [MODERATE CONFIDENCE, SCENARIO-CONDITIONED]

Documented open-source reporting indicates Saudi Vision 2030's mining pillar targets $110B in investment (Saudi Ministry of Industry and Ma'aden public documentation [TIER 2]) and UAE's overseas mineral acquisition strategy has produced documented acquisitions through Manara Minerals and IRH Fund [TIER 2]. USGS Mineral Commodity Summaries 2025 documents GCC critical mineral development pipelines in copper, rare earth oxides, lithium carbonate, phosphate, and niobium. [TIER 1]

These findings support a moderate-confidence judgment that GCC mineral development pipelines represent an available economic foundation for a positive-sum partnership architecture. The window for execution is assessed at 12-24 months while GCC reassessment of China dependency is active under scenario conditions. The public record does not establish that Saudi Vision 2030 mineral output will reach commercial scale within the 1-5 year planning horizon sufficient to make Chinese supply chain integration meaningfully coercive on that timeline. [SCENARIO-CONDITIONED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE]

> **IMPLEMENTATION FRICTION**
>
> Saudi Vision 2030's critical mineral output is not yet at commercial scale on timelines that would

> make Chinese supply chain integration meaningfully coercive within the 1-5 year planning horizon. UAE overseas stakes are minority positions in projects with their own development cycles. The mineral partnership's near-term value is primarily as signaling and bargaining leverage, not as an immediately operative supply-chain coercion mechanism. China will offer competitive counter-bids. The US advantage is the security guarantee, not price — but that framing must be made explicit in GCC bilateral engagement or the economic comparison alone favors China. [MODERATE CONFIDENCE on framework logic; LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE on near-term coercive potency]

3.3 Component 2: Gulf Maritime Forum Institutionalization [MODERATE CONFIDENCE, SCENARIO-CONDITIONED]

The Gulf Maritime Forum architecture developed in HORMUZ-02 is documented as the institutional instrument for converting kinetic advantage into structural constraint. Documented open-source reporting indicates China's crude supply dependency on Hormuz transit creates a structural interest in a stable, rules-based transit regime. [TIER 1 — EIA STEO March 2026] These findings support a moderate-confidence judgment that China needs the Forum more than it needs to avoid joining it, because the US is the only actor that can provide the guaranteed transit regime China depends on — under scenario conditions where Chinese bypass alternatives are insufficient. The Claim Dependency Map (Tier B above) establishes that this claim is scenario-conditioned: outside crisis conditions, Chinese bypass investments materially reduce this calculus. The public record does not permit a firm conclusion on whether China's INSTC and bypass architecture investment reduces that dependency sufficiently to make Forum membership non-compulsory on the stated timeline. [SCENARIO-CONDITIONED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE]

A sophisticated alternative hypothesis must also be addressed: China may respond to Forum pressure not with participation but with hedging, delay, parallel institution-building, and selective compliance. Great powers regularly respond to coercive institutional design with contestation rather than accommodation. The architecture's answer to this objection is structural rather than behavioral: the leverage operates through supply chain economics, not through Chinese institutional receptivity. If China chooses obstruction, the cost is borne in crude supply reliability at a moment when bypass alternatives are insufficient. That structural dynamic does not require Chinese receptivity — but it does require that the scenario conditions persist long enough for the structural logic to operate. [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE on structural mechanism; LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE on Chinese choice under pressure]

This clarification also answers the question of why Forum launch is classified as a necessary condition even when Chinese membership at launch is not predicted. The Forum’s necessity is independent of Chinese participation. Forum initiation within the crisis window serves three functions that operate regardless of Chinese behavior: (1) it locks in GCC partner state commitments to a US-designed transit architecture at the moment of maximum crisis urgency, creating legal and reputational exit costs before GCC states revert to peacetime bargaining postures; (2) it establishes the UNCLOS Article 38 institutional framework that makes future Chinese participation less politically costly to accept than continued refusal, once bypass alternatives remain structurally insufficient; and (3) it forecloses Chinese bilateral exploitation of ad hoc Hormuz stabilization arrangements by anchoring the transit regime in multilateral institutional form. The Forum is a necessary condition because of what it does to partner state commitment and institutional framing — not because Chinese membership is expected at initiation. A Forum that China does not join at launch but cannot easily contest or replace is

strategically preferable to no Forum. [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE]

The OSCE model is instructive at the concept level but the analogy has documented limits. HORMUZ-02 Section 5.3 establishes that the Helsinki process succeeded because participating states had already accepted the status quo being codified, whereas Iran is not positioned to accept the full normative premises of a UNCLOS-derived transit regime on current terms. Koremenos, Lipson, and Snidal's 'Rational Design of International Institutions' (2001) establishes that membership scope, centralization, rules, and flexibility must all be calibrated to the specific compliance problem. These findings support a moderate-confidence judgment that the near-term Forum mechanism is best understood through the lens of the 1987-88 Gulf naval de-confliction arrangements rather than the full Helsinki process. The public record does not establish Iranian willingness to participate even at observer level. [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE on Iranian participation]

3.4 Component 3: BRI Debt-Trap Node Displacement [MODERATE CONFIDENCE, ANALYTICALLY INFERRED]

AidData's 'Banking on Beijing' (2021) documents hidden collateral clauses in multiple Chinese Exim Bank agreements, including one granting China access to Kenya Ports Authority revenues upon default. [TIER 2 — AidData, Banking on Beijing, 2021, pp. 44-47] Jones and Hameiri (2020) find that host country agency, domestic politics, and renegotiation dynamics prevent deliberate debt entrapment from being a reliable Chinese strategy. These findings are consistent with Brautigam's (2020) empirical case studies, which document that debt structures create future leverage options China may exercise when conditions are favorable, independent of original design intent. This paper uses 'debt-trap risk' to describe that structural consequence, not to assert deliberate entrapment as the design intent. The public record does not establish that China has exercised collateral enforcement against any node other than Hambantota.

A critical narrowing must be acknowledged: the evidence base demonstrates that some BRI nodes are contestable under favorable domestic circumstances, not that they are broadly susceptible to coalition-displaceable leverage on the architecture's required timeline. The claim is more limited than it may appear in integrated-architecture presentation: targeted displacement at Tier 3 nodes where pre-operational windows remain open, not systemic BRI rollback. [MODERATE CONFIDENCE on contingent leverage characterization; LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE on replication likelihood and breadth]

USGS Mineral Commodity Summaries 2025 documents Bolivia as holding the world's largest lithium reserves. [TIER 1] Documented open-source reporting indicates CATL and CITIC agreements are not yet at full operational scale. [TIER 2] These findings support a moderate-confidence judgment that the pre-operational window for Bolivia lithium displacement remains open. The public record does not establish that Bolivia's current government would accept US-allied development finance conditionality; prior DFC engagement with Bolivia has not converted to active coordination. [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE on window availability; LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE on Bolivian receptivity]

3.5 Component 4: Russian Isolation Through Superior Alternative Provision [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE]

Documented open-source reporting indicates the Rosneft full SDN designation under EO 14024 on October 22, 2025 creates the operational reality in which Russia sells oil to China through Zabaykalsk at prices China dictates. [TIER 1 — OFAC SDN List, EO 14024, October 22, 2025] These findings support a moderate-confidence judgment that this constitutes Chinese

monopsony leverage over Russian energy exports, not a Russian strategic victory. The public record does not establish the precise degree to which China exploits this leverage in commodity pricing; available evidence is consistent with the judgment that it does. [MODERATE CONFIDENCE, ANALYTICALLY INFERRED]

The indirect isolation mechanism is analytically inferred: if China can secure Gulf crude through a US-guaranteed transit regime and GCC mineral partnerships, the marginal value of discounted Russian crude through ESPO decreases. The enforcement pressure layer — SENI-01 Tier I priority targets: Skovorodino ESPO fork, Zabaykalsk gauge switch, Sabetta LNG, Zvezda Shipyard — complements the positive-sum diplomatic architecture by degrading Russian energy export reliability at the moment the US-GCC alternative is being offered. This component is the most downstream of the four and doubly contingent: it requires both the scenario to persist and GCC/Forum components to be functional. The public record does not establish the degree to which these two instruments would operate synchronously in practice. [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE; SCENARIO-CONDITIONED and DOUBLY CONTINGENT per Tier C of Claim Dependency Map]

Part IV: India — Strategic Posture and Coalition Design Implications

4.1 Strategic Autonomy Assessment [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE]

Documented open-source reporting on Modi government decision-making indicates willingness to accept significant alignment costs when the strategic calculus favored it — Quad deepening and defence technology cooperation are documented cases. [TIER 2 — Carnegie, C. Raja Mohan; Ashley Tellis] Shivshankar Menon's memoirs and Ashley Tellis's Carnegie analyses document India's strategic calculus as more instrumentally flexible than a structural constraint framing implies.

These findings support the judgment that whether strategic autonomy is structurally embedded or instrumentally managed, any architecture requiring India to formally abandon it will fail within the five-to-ten year crisis window. The question is not whether India could join a formal US-led coalition under the right conditions, but whether those conditions are achievable given current US-India friction on tariffs, technology transfer restrictions, and the unresolved S-400 secondary sanctions question. The public record does not permit a firm conclusion on where India's strategic autonomy calculus sits on the structural-to-instrumental spectrum. [MODERATE CONFIDENCE on strategic logic; LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE on specific willingness assessments]

4.2 Interests Assessment and Prior Engagement Record [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE]

India's structural interests in the corridor competition are specific and documented: Chinese BRI port access in Sri Lanka constrained; no Chinese naval basing at Gwadar; Central Asian connectivity independent of Pakistani overland routes; continued access to discounted Russian energy while economically rational. Tanvi Madan's 'Fateful Triangle' (2020) documents India's consistent interest in constraining Chinese Indian Ocean positioning. These findings support a moderate-confidence judgment that these interests are structurally aligned with the coalition's interests without requiring India to join anything formally. The public record does not establish that India has translated these interests into active coordination with US coalition partners at the operational level. [MODERATE CONFIDENCE, ANALYTICALLY INFERRED]

The US has offered support for India's Chabahar investment since 2018 with limited success in converting that offer into active bilateral coordination. Documented open-source reporting indicates Chabahar port operational status is uncertain under scenario conditions. [TIER 2 — CSIS, Carnegie] These findings support the judgment that the current moment is structurally different from prior engagement attempts, but are not sufficient to establish that India's receptivity to a DFC co-investment offer has changed materially. The public record does not permit a firm conclusion on Indian receptivity given current tariff friction. [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE on Indian receptivity]

4.3 The Transactional Gap: From Structural Alignment to Operational Cooperation

A critical distinction must be drawn between identifying India's structural incentives — which this paper does with moderate confidence — and specifying the bargaining package that would

convert parallel-beneficiary status into active operational enabling behavior. The paper is stronger on the former than the latter, and this asymmetry should be read as a real analytic limitation.

The minimum bargaining package required to move Delhi from passive benefit to active coordination is not fully derivable from the open-source record. The available evidence is consistent with the judgment that it would require at minimum: (1) credible US signal of willingness to address tariff asymmetries bilaterally, (2) Forum architecture explicitly designed to accommodate India's continuing S-400 program and Russian energy imports, and (3) DFC co-investment terms that do not require India to formalize its security alignment. Whether those three conditions are achievable on the architecture's timeline is assessed as LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE. [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE]

IMPLEMENTATION FRICTION

Current US-India friction — tariff tensions, technology transfer restrictions, unresolved S-400 question — is the primary constraint on converting the parallel-beneficiary framing into operational coordination on the timeline the architecture requires. Indian Forum membership requires resolution of at least some of this friction, or Forum design explicitly compatible with India's continued S-400 program and Russian energy imports. This is a harder diplomatic ask than the architecture implies if stated without qualification. The public record does not establish that current US-India friction is on a trajectory toward resolution within the five-year crisis window. [LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE]

Part V: Structural Constraints and Confidence Boundaries

5.1 Execution Requirements and Historical Performance Baseline

The positive-sum framing is strategically correct but execution-demanding. The available evidence is consistent with the judgment that concurrent execution of four components across multiple bureaucracies and coalition partners, sustained over a five-to-ten year horizon through at minimum one and possibly two US presidential administration transitions, is required. Historical US grand strategy performance does not establish that this level of sustained institutional will is achievable; the public record is consistent with both positive and negative precedents on comparable sustained multilateral campaigns. [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE]

5.2 Three Structural Limits

China's Electrification Hedge [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, MODERATE-HIGH CONFIDENCE on direction; LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE on specific timeline]

IEA World Energy Outlook 2024 documents China's fossil fuel share of total energy consumption declining through 2030. [TIER 2 — IEA WEO 2024] These findings support a moderate-high-confidence judgment that China's Hormuz leverage exposure is declining structurally. The GCC mineral partnership and Gulf Maritime Forum must be built and locked in during the current window, not deferred. The public record does not permit a firm conclusion on the precise timeline at which Chinese fossil fuel dependency falls below the threshold that compels Forum participation. [LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE on specific timeline]

The Saudi Treaty Variable [SCENARIO-CONDITIONED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE on direction; LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE on timeline]

Documented open-source reporting indicates the Saudi-US defense treaty negotiation was linked to the Saudi-Israeli normalization track prior to October 2023, and that Saudi civilian nuclear rights remain a live negotiating question. [TIER 2 — open-source foreign policy reporting] These findings support a moderate-confidence judgment that the treaty requires sustained US political commitment across potential administration changes, Saudi willingness to accept nonproliferation conditions on the civilian nuclear program, and progress on Israeli normalization that may be blocked by regional politics. The public record does not establish that these conditions are achievable on the 3-12 month timeline the architecture requires. Without the treaty, the GCC mineral architecture rests on ad hoc arrangements that are renegotiable. [SCENARIO-CONDITIONED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE on direction; LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE on timeline]

The Verification Gap in Chinese IRGC Decoupling [SCENARIO-CONDITIONED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE on framework; LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE on entity-level compliance]

HORMUZ-02 Section 8.2 and SHIELD-01 Section 8 document the composite proxy verification methodology and its limits. OFAC public enforcement records are consistent with the judgment that Chinese state and state-affiliated entities conduct IRGC-linked oil trade through structures deliberately opaque to these proxy indicators. These findings support the judgment that the architecture's credibility rests on Chinese self-interest in maintaining access, not on the

achievability of complete verification. The public record does not establish that Chinese self-interest in maintaining Forum access will prove sufficient to overcome political incentives to continue IRGC-linked trade. [MODERATE CONFIDENCE on framework logic; LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE on entity-level compliance achievability]

5.3 Adversary Knowledge and Enforcement Architecture Resilience

The positive-sum architecture described here is derivable from open-source analysis. The CI Assessment companion to this series — WP-2026-CI-Assessment-v2.0 (March 2026), publicly available at github.com/collingeorge/WP-2026/00-series-standards/ — documents the adversary utility of the integrated WP-2026 series and applies established open-source CI exposure methodology to the repository content. Available open-source reporting on adversary OSINT collection practices is consistent with the judgment that China's MSS, Russia's SVR, and Iran's MOIS have likely collected the series. [TIER 2 — WP-2026-CI-Assessment-v2.0, March 2026]

These findings support the judgment that adversary awareness of the architecture does not defeat it. The architecture works through structural interests and legal authorities, not through information asymmetry. The public record does not establish that adversary awareness of the enforcement framework has reduced its operational effectiveness in prior maximum pressure contexts; available evidence from Iran and Russia sanctions practice is consistent with the judgment that awareness does not defeat enforcement. The goal is precisely to build an architecture that sustains US interests without requiring permanent forward presence — an architecture that Mearsheimer's offshore balancing critique would not predict is achievable from a permanent forward-deployed posture, but which the institutional lock-in argument addresses directly.[2] [MODERATE CONFIDENCE, ANALYTICALLY INFERRED]

Part VI: Implementation Sequencing and Timeline Assessment

6.1 First-Order Actions (0-30 Days) [SCENARIO-CONDITIONED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE]

Three actions are assessed as the highest-leverage first-order interventions available in the 0-30 day window. Each carries real bureaucratic and political constraints that have prevented execution to date and that the urgency of scenario conditions does not automatically resolve.

1. The UAE island sovereignty diplomatic offer is assessed as the highest-leverage first-order action available in the 0-30 day window. The Abu Musa and Tunb claim is documented as the concrete US deliverable that secures Fujairah MCM basing and Al Dhafra strike access. [TIER 2 — HORMUZ-02 Part III] The political constraint is that US active support requires managing Israeli sensitivity about creating precedents for territorial dispute resolution in the Gulf and State Department legal clearance on UNCLOS implications. These constraints are solvable but not trivial. The public record does not establish that these constraints have been addressed or that US political will to execute the offer currently exists. [SCENARIO-CONDITIONED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE]
2. Opening the Oman back-channel toward exit terms for the Kharg occupation is assessed as the second-highest-leverage first-order action, requiring initiation within the 0-30 day window to prevent compounding legal and administrative costs. HORMUZ-02 Part X documents the occupation's accruing obligation structure. The political constraint is that under scenario conditions, any US back-channel communication risks being read domestically as a signal of strategic uncertainty. Oman is documented as the only viable back-channel mechanism. [TIER 2 — HORMUZ-02 Part X] The public record does not establish current Omani willingness to serve as intermediary for a belligerent occupier. [SCENARIO-CONDITIONED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE]
3. DFC and JBIC engagement with Bolivia on lithium refinancing is assessed as the third first-order action, with the pre-operational window documented as open based on CATL and CITIC agreements not yet reaching full operational scale. [TIER 2 — SENI-01 §XL] The political constraint is Bolivia's documented ideological resistance to Western finance conditionality. A competitive offer structured to respect Bolivian sovereignty visibly is assessed as necessary but not sufficient to overcome prior resistance. The public record does not establish that this framing would overcome prior resistance within the 0-30 day window. [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE on Bolivian receptivity]

6.2 30-90 Day Diplomatic and Institutional Layer [SCENARIO-CONDITIONED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE]

Hormuz Transit Conference convening signal. Documented open-source reporting indicates Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi expressed that China is 'deeply concerned' about the widening conflict and called on all sides to safeguard maritime passage. [TIER 2 — Bloomberg, 'China Calls on All Sides to Protect Ships Transiting Hormuz,' March 3, 2026] These findings support a moderate-confidence judgment that the public announcement of a multilateral conference framework signals to China that Hormuz stabilization will occur through a US-designed institutional architecture or through continued crisis. The public record does not

establish Chinese receptivity to a US-convened multilateral forum before Chinese diplomatic posture hardens into opposition. [SCENARIO-CONDITIONED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE]

Saudi spare capacity commitment in exchange for treaty framework engagement. Documented open-source reporting indicates Saudi spare capacity is estimated at 3.5-4.5 million bpd. [TIER 1 — EIA STEO March 2026] Treaty framework engagement — not treaty finalization — is assessed as achievable in 30-90 days with sustained US political commitment. The constraint is that the Saudi civilian nuclear rights question cannot be deferred indefinitely without losing Saudi confidence in the framework's seriousness. The public record does not establish current Saudi willingness to activate spare capacity in exchange for treaty framework engagement rather than treaty finalization. [SCENARIO-CONDITIONED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE]

India MCM data-sharing activation. The bilateral MCM data-sharing arrangement requires no formal coalition commitment from India. The available evidence is consistent with the judgment that this offer needs to be accompanied by a signal of US willingness to address the tariff question bilaterally — or the MCM offer will be received as asking India to provide security services while the US simultaneously applies economic pressure. The public record does not permit a firm conclusion on whether that tariff signal is achievable in the 30-90 day window. [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE]

6.3 3-24 Month Structural Build [SCENARIO-CONDITIONED, LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE on completion]

Gulf Maritime Forum institutionalization, GCC mineral partnership formalization, BRI Tier 2 node diplomatic engagement, and the Digital Silk Road countermeasure architecture are all 3-24 month execution timeframes. The available evidence is consistent with the judgment that these initiatives must begin during the crisis window because beginning during the crisis locks in the strategic framing that these are crisis-driven security responses, not peacetime commercial competition. The public record does not establish that US bureaucratic and coalition coordination capacity is sufficient to execute all four components concurrently on this timeline. [SCENARIO-CONDITIONED, LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE on completion]

Part VII: Failure Analysis — Degradation Pathways and Architecture Collapse Conditions

This section is not a limitations section. It is a structured analysis of how the architecture fails, what the failure looks like at each severity level, and which failure modes produce catastrophic collapse versus degraded but partially functional outcomes. Assessing failure pathways is necessary for evaluating which components of the architecture are worth prioritizing under resource constraints and which are optional. The minimum coalition-effective architecture defined in Section 8.3 is derived in part from this analysis.

7.1 First-Break Dynamics: What Fails First

The Saudi treaty is assessed as the most likely first point of failure, for three compound reasons: it is the single component requiring sustained US political commitment across an administration transition; it is the component most susceptible to regional blocking dynamics (Israeli normalization, Iranian spoiler behavior); and it is the component where Saudi domestic politics create the highest probability of renegotiation demands that derail the timeline. Failure of the Saudi treaty does not collapse the architecture. It downgrades it from a decade-level lock-in to an ad hoc arrangement requiring periodic renegotiation. GCC mineral partnerships can proceed without the treaty; Forum institutionalization can proceed without the treaty; Russian isolation through superior alternative provision can proceed without the treaty. The treaty converts all three from contingent to durable. Its loss is significant but not catastrophic. [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE]

The second most likely first failure is India's continued passive posture. If tariff friction is not addressed and S-400 secondary sanctions remain unresolved, India remains a parallel beneficiary but does not convert to operational coordination. The Forum proceeds without Indian membership; the mineral partnerships proceed without Indian co-investment; Russian isolation proceeds without Indian logistical cooperation. The architecture loses depth but not its core mechanism. [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE]

The third most likely first failure is Chinese counter-institutionalization. China's most rational response to Forum pressure is not confrontational refusal but diplomatic delay combined with parallel institution-building — proposing alternative multilateral maritime frameworks under ASEAN or SCO auspices, selectively engaging Forum mechanisms while contesting their normative content, and extending INSTC investment to accelerate bypass alternative timelines. This response does not break the architecture immediately; it degrades the leverage window by extending the timeline for Chinese fossil fuel dependency to fall below the compulsion threshold. [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE on Chinese strategic logic; LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE on specific Chinese choice]

7.2 Partial Execution Pathways and Degraded Outcomes

Scenario A: Treaty Stalls, Other Three Components Proceed

If GCC mineral partnerships, Forum institutionalization, and BRI node displacement proceed without the treaty, the architecture delivers meaningful but time-limited structural advantage. GCC mineral partnerships create real Chinese supply chain switching costs on a 3-7 year horizon. Forum institutionalization creates legal and reputational costs for Chinese exit even

without a permanent US-Saudi security treaty anchor. BRI Tier 2 and 3 node displacement creates competitive alternatives at the most contestable points. What is lost without the treaty: the permanent security architecture that prevents GCC states from renegotiating their positions after the crisis window closes. The scenario-A architecture requires active US maintenance rather than operating through institutional self-enforcement. [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE on degraded functionality; LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE on GCC durability without treaty]

Scenario B: India Remains Passive, Treaty Proceeds

If India remains a passive parallel beneficiary without converting to operational coordination, the Forum operates as a GCC-centered institution without Indian Ocean depth. Chinese BRI maritime positioning in Sri Lanka, Bangladesh, and Myanmar remains more contestable with Indian operational cooperation and less contestable without it. The Russian isolation mechanism is unaffected by Indian posture — India's continued Russian energy imports under scenario conditions actually serve US interests by maintaining the wedge between China and Russia on energy pricing. The architecture is modestly weaker without Indian operational cooperation but not architecturally compromised. [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE]

Scenario C: China Hedges and Delays Rather Than Participating

If China responds to Forum pressure with strategic delay rather than participation, the coercive mechanism operates more slowly. The structural logic does not require Chinese cooperation — it requires Chinese crude supply to remain Hormuz-dependent, which is a logistics constraint rather than a policy choice. If the leverage window is five to ten years and Chinese electrification reduces fossil fuel dependency at the upper end of IEA projections, US coalition control of Hormuz transit during years one through five creates the lock-in window regardless of Chinese Forum participation choice. Forum membership is the preferred outcome; Forum-adjacent compliance through self-interest in transit reliability is the minimum outcome. What defeats this scenario is if China accelerates bypass architecture investment sufficiently to shift the Hormuz dependency below compulsion threshold before institutional lock-in is complete. [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE on structural mechanism; LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE on specific timeline sensitivity]

Scenario D: BRI Displacement Succeeds at Only a Few Nodes

If BRI displacement succeeds only at Bolivia lithium and one or two Tier 2 pre-operational nodes, the displacement component's strategic significance is signaling rather than structural. The three-node case demonstrates competitive US-allied development finance capacity and creates precedents for host country bargaining with China, but does not materially alter BRI's geographic footprint. The architecture does not require systemic BRI rollback — that claim was explicitly rejected in the v4.0 reframe. Limited displacement success is a meaningful but bounded contribution. [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE]

Scenario E: US Coalition Persistence Erodes After Administration Transition

Administration transition is the highest-severity failure mode in the architecture's execution timeline. If the incoming US administration de-prioritizes Forum institutionalization or GCC mineral partnership follow-through, the components that depend on sustained political commitment — the treaty, the Forum, the DFC/JBIC pipeline — are most exposed. Components that have been institutionally locked in before the transition — GCC mineral offtake agreements embedded in Chinese supply chains, Forum mechanisms codified in UNCLOS Article 38 frameworks, BRI displacement agreements with host country governments — survive

administration transition because the switching costs run to partner states, not to US political will. This is precisely why front-loading institutional lock-in during the crisis window is the architecture's highest-priority strategic logic. Any component that has not been locked in before an administration transition must be treated as contingent. [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE]

7.3 Architecture Collapse Conditions

The architecture does not collapse through any single component failure. It collapses through the interaction of two concurrent failures: coalition persistence erosion combined with Chinese success in accelerating bypass alternatives sufficiently to reduce Hormuz dependency below the compulsion threshold before institutional lock-in is complete. Either failure alone produces degradation; their combination produces collapse. The probability of concurrent failure on this specific timeline is not established from the public record. [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE]

A secondary collapse path exists through adversary military escalation that forecloses the positive-sum institutional track entirely — specifically, an Iranian escalation under scenario conditions that produces direct US-China military confrontation over Hormuz transit, converting the leverage window from an institutional opportunity into an active military crisis. That path exits the architecture's analytical scope and is addressed in HORMUZ-02. [SCENARIO-CONDITIONED]

> **FAILURE ANALYSIS SUMMARY**
>
> First-break: Saudi treaty stall (most likely, not catastrophic). Second: India passive posture (moderately likely, architecture functional without it). Third: Chinese counter-institutionalization (likely, degrades timeline not mechanism).
>
> Degraded but functional (3 of 4 components): Architecture produces time-limited structural advantage without decade-level lock-in. Requires active maintenance rather than institutional self-enforcement.
>
> Collapse condition: Concurrent coalition persistence erosion AND Chinese bypass acceleration below compulsion threshold before lock-in. Either failure alone produces degradation, not collapse.

Part VIII: Final Assessment and Minimum Coalition-Effective Architecture

8.1 Conditional Opportunity Space Assessment [MODERATE-HIGH CONFIDENCE, SCENARIO-CONDITIONED THROUGHOUT]

This architecture identifies a real but conditional strategic opportunity space. The corridor wager China made — that Hormuz would remain outside effective US coercive reach on any planning horizon — has been operationally tested under the scenario premise. The structural findings in Parts I-II are scenario-independent: BRI's hub-and-spoke convergence on the Hormuz-Malacca corridor is documented, the leverage window is finite and declining, and contingent leverage at BRI Tier 3 nodes is established through AidData's evidentiary record. These findings would be strategically relevant in any world in which Hormuz corridor disruption is a policy instrument available to the US.

The forward-looking architecture in Parts III-VI is scenario-conditioned: achievability depends on concurrent execution of a minimum necessary subset of components under unusually favorable political conditions. The paper's claim is not that the architecture will be executed or that the corridor wager is winnable in general. It is that the structural conditions for a durable US coalition corridor advantage are available right now, that the window for building institutional lock-in is finite and declining, and that the minimum coalition-effective subset required for meaningful strategic advantage is smaller than the full concurrent package — making partial execution more tractable than the integrated architecture framing implies.

First, concurrent execution. The PERSIST-01 escalation ladder and MAXPRESS-01 enforcement architecture are documented as the synchronization instruments. Sequential execution allows adversary adaptation. Hufbauer, Schott, and Elliott's findings on multilateral sanction effectiveness and Drezner's credibility-vulnerability framework both support the judgment that concurrent execution with credible alternatives is the architecturally superior approach. The architecture is strongest when all four components execute concurrently; Section 8.3 defines what remains achievable when they do not. [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE]

Second, India integration as parallel beneficiary by deliberate institutional design. Every institutional framework must be designed so that Indian membership is compatible with strategic autonomy and current friction points. The available evidence is consistent with the judgment that this requires more active US flexibility on tariff and S-400 questions than current posture reflects. The public record does not establish that such flexibility is achievable on the relevant timeline. [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE]

Third, the Saudi treaty. The ad hoc spare capacity arrangement buys 3-12 months. The treaty buys the decade. The nonproliferation conditions question at the treaty's center cannot be resolved by analytic argument — it requires sustained US political commitment at the level of an administration priority. Failure of the treaty produces scenario A (Part VII): degraded but functional architecture. [SCENARIO-CONDITIONED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE on direction; LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE on timeline]

Fourth, institutional lock-in before the leverage window closes. The Gulf Maritime Forum, GCC mineral partnerships, and BRI debt-trap displacement must be operational and embedded in partner state economic interests before Chinese fossil fuel dependency declines to the point

where the leverage no longer compels Forum participation. The public record does not establish the precise timeline at which that threshold is crossed. [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE]

The architecture's defining strategic property is that it is self-reinforcing once established — but only if the minimum coalition-effective subset is achieved before the leverage window closes. GCC mineral partnerships operationally embedded in Chinese supply chains create switching costs that grow over time. Gulf Maritime Forum membership codified in UNCLOS Article 38 frameworks creates legal and reputational costs for exit. BRI debt-trap displacement that replaces Chinese Exim Bank lending with US-allied development finance creates economic dependencies that run toward the coalition. The available evidence is consistent with the judgment that this self-reinforcing end-state is structurally available under scenario conditions — not that it will be reached. The public record does not permit a firm conclusion on whether concurrent execution requirements will be met or whether institutional lock-in will be achieved before the leverage window closes. What the evidence does support is the narrower claim: the structural opportunity space is real, the mechanisms are individually plausible under scenario premises, and the minimum coalition-effective architecture is less demanding than full concurrent execution. Whether US political and institutional capacity will meet even that reduced threshold is assessed as scenario-conditioned and not determinable from open-source analysis alone. [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE on structural availability; SCENARIO-CONDITIONED on execution; LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE on concurrent execution requirements being met]

8.2 Necessary vs. Sufficient: The Architecture's Internal Hierarchy

The concurrent architecture has been criticized, correctly, for presenting all components as mutually reinforcing without specifying which are essential. The following hierarchy resolves that gap. It is analytically inferred from the structural logic of the architecture and from the failure analysis in Part VII. This matrix is an analytic prioritization instrument — it reflects the paper’s assessment of which components are load-bearing under scenario conditions. It is not an empirical demonstration that these elements are readily obtainable, and it should not be read as a claim that even the necessary conditions are achievable on the stated timeline. The confidence assessments attached to each component in Parts III-VI govern obtainability; the hierarchy here governs relative strategic priority.

TIER	COMPONENTS AND DEFINITION
NECESSARY CONDITIONS	Without these, the architecture fails entirely or loses its defining strategic property. 1. Coalition maintenance of effective Hormuz transit influence through the leverage window — the structural foundation on which all other components rest. 2. Gulf Maritime Forum initiation within the crisis window — the primary instrument for converting kinetic advantage into structural constraint. Can proceed without Saudi treaty; cannot proceed without coalition transit influence. 3. GCC mineral partnership initiation within the 12-24 month crisis window — the economic layer that gives Forum membership independent value for GCC states. Signaling value is near-term; coercive potency is 3-7 years.
SUFFICIENT ENHANCERS	Materially improve probability and durability of the architecture's success. Not required for minimum coalition-effective outcome.

TIER	COMPONENTS AND DEFINITION
	4. Saudi-US defense treaty — converts GCC architecture from ad hoc to decade-level lock-in. Highest-value enhancer. Failure produces scenario A degradation, not collapse. 5. India as operational enabler (beyond passive parallel beneficiary) — adds Indian Ocean depth to Forum and degrades Chinese BRI maritime positioning in Sri Lanka and Bangladesh more rapidly.
SCENARIO ACCELERANTS	Not necessary in all worlds; meaningfully increase leverage speed and scope under crisis conditions. 6. BRI Tier 2 node displacement (pre-operational windows at Tier 2 nodes) — demonstrates competitive US-allied development finance and creates host country bargaining precedents. Valuable but bounded; does not alter BRI's structural footprint. 7. Enforcement pressure on Russian energy export infrastructure (SENI-01 Tier I nodes) — complements positive-sum architecture by degrading Russian export reliability at the moment GCC alternative is being offered. Doubly contingent.
OPTIONAL EXTENSIONS	Useful but nonessential. Can be pursued if bandwidth permits; failure does not affect core architecture. 8. Digital Silk Road countermeasure architecture — valuable at decade horizon; not load-bearing in the five-year leverage window. 9. Bolivia lithium displacement — high-value signal if achieved; not structurally required for the GCC mineral partnership's core coercive mechanism.

8.3 Minimum Coalition-Effective Architecture

If only a subset of the architecture is achievable given bureaucratic, political, and timeline constraints, the minimum coalition-effective architecture is defined as: the necessary conditions (1-3 above) executed successfully, with at minimum one sufficient enhancer (4 or 5) initiated before the first US administration transition.

> **MINIMUM COALITION-EFFECTIVE ARCHITECTURE DEFINITION**
>
> **Minimum coalition-effective: Coalition transit influence maintained + Forum initiated + GCC mineral partnership initiated + Saudi treaty engaged (even if not finalized) OR India parallel-beneficiary conversion to at least MCM data-sharing operational coordination.**
>
> This subset produces: time-limited structural advantage without decade-level self-enforcement; meaningful Chinese supply chain switching costs on a 3-7 year horizon; legal and reputational costs for Chinese Forum exit even without Saudi treaty anchor; GCC states with genuine economic alternatives to Chinese development finance. What it does not produce without the treaty: an institutional architecture that enforces itself through partner state self-interest across administration transitions.
>
> Minimum coalition-effective architecture confidence: LOW-MODERATE on full concurrent execution within window; MODERATE on initiating at least necessary conditions 1-3 under scenario conditions; MODERATE-HIGH on structural availability of the opportunity space if the scenario premise holds.

The minimum coalition-effective architecture framing is the paper's most important contribution to the winnability debate. The corridor wager is not an all-or-nothing proposition. A US coalition that achieves only the necessary conditions and one sufficient enhancer has still materially

altered the strategic environment for China and Russia on a five-to-seven year horizon, at lower execution cost and political risk than the full concurrent architecture implies. The question is not whether the US can execute the corridor wager comprehensively. The question is whether the minimum coalition-effective subset is structurally available and worth attempting under scenario conditions — and on that question, the structural evidence is favorable. Whether US political and institutional capacity is equal to that reduced threshold remains scenario-conditioned and is not resolved by this analysis. [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE on minimum coalition-effective assessment; SCENARIO-CONDITIONED on achievability]

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- WP-2026-HORMUZ-01/02 v4.1 — posture architecture, partner matrix, diplomatic sequencing, mineral framework, Kharg occupation analysis
- WP-2026-PERSIST-01 — five-pillar framework, authority rails, escalation ladder, guardrail index
- WP-2026-CONTAIN-01 — ISAD/SPAD/DEEI doctrine, 90-day observability cycle
- WP-2026-MAXPRESS-01 — execution layer; simultaneous BIS/OFAC; Lloyd's degradation mechanism
- WP-2026-SHIELD-01 v7 — CCRP; five-rung nexus ladder application; PRC-facilitated network enforcement
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- WP-2026-CI-Assessment-v2.0 (March 2026) — open-source counterintelligence exposure assessment of the WP-2026 series; publicly available at github.com/collingeorge/WP-2026/00-series-standards/

Footnotes

[1] *Two Vortexa figures appear in this document and should be read carefully: (1) the pre-crisis 2025 baseline of ~51% of Chinese seaborne crude imports transiting Hormuz, which is the strategically relevant figure for leverage window assessment; and (2) the Q1 2026 crisis-period figure of ~35%, which reflects a sharp increase in Russian seaborne imports that may not persist post-crisis. The body text in Sections 1.2 and 1.3 specifies which vintage applies at each point of use. The leverage window argument in Section 1.3 is based on the 2025 pre-crisis baseline, not the crisis-period adjustment. The 6% total energy figure corresponds to the 35% Q1 2026 crude figure applied against China's energy mix (oil ~18% of total energy, of which ~35% transits Hormuz = ~6% of total energy). The 9% figure using the 2025 baseline (51% x 18%) is the more conservative and strategically relevant calculation. Sources: Vortexa, 'China's Crude Import Stress Resistance in a Hormuz Crisis,' March 2026; IEA WEO 2024.*

[2] *Mearsheimer and Walt's offshore balancing critique (Foreign Affairs, 2016) argues that US forward engagement in the Middle East creates entanglement costs that exceed strategic benefits and recommends retrenchment to offshore positions. The institutional lock-in argument in this paper addresses the Mearsheimer-Walt critique directly: the goal is not permanent forward military presence but an institutional architecture embedded in partner state economic interests that sustains US strategic interests without requiring a permanent forward garrison. If the Forum, mineral partnerships, and BRI debt-trap displacement operate as designed, the US can withdraw to an overwatch posture — which is precisely the end-state the offshore balancing critique prescribes. The disagreement with Mearsheimer-Walt is not about the desirability of retrenchment but about whether the institutional architecture described here can achieve retrenchment while preserving US strategic interests. That question is assessed as scenario-conditioned and not resolvable from open-source analysis alone.*

NOTICE: This paper is unclassified open-source academic and policy analysis. No classified information was used. All assessments are drawn from published literature, government reports, and established policy analysis organizations. Legal analysis is for analytic framing only. All forward-looking assessments are scenario-conditioned and should not be read as predictions.

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